



STATUS REPORT

Djibouti — digital transformation and data governance status report

Edition of 2026-09-05 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

Djibouti's 2026 budget law names no ICT ministry line, no ANSIE allocation and no e-government envelope, so the digital mandates it creates — the customs single window, the Fichier Unique update and the budget data-exchange platform — are unfunded in the published appropriation.

The umbrella above those mandates changed in mid-2026. The third National Development Plan, **PND-ADEEG 2025-2030**, was adopted by decree in Council of Ministers on 30 June 2026 as the successor framework to Vision 2035, and the flagship Smart Nation Strategy is being revised rather than newly launched, the World Bank's eighth implementation report recording a decision to align it with the new plan and the new cybersecurity agency and to prioritise operationalising the Digital Code's telecommunications and cybersecurity books. The government's own October 2025 digital-maturity diagnostic listed as still outstanding the instruments the Code enables: a national digital strategy and sectoral roadmaps, data-management and cybersecurity policies, and infrastructure modernisation and cloud adoption.

The artificial-intelligence strategy is the clearest case. It remained announced but unadopted and unpublished through August 2026, scheduled for launch alongside the national AI-readiness conclusions at the country's first National Forum on Artificial Intelligence on 2-3 September 2026, and is led by the ministry responsible for education, innovation and digital development with UNESCO and UN-ESCWA support. The Universal Service Fund is at a similar stage: a feedback meeting on 20 April 2026 considered the final report defining its regulatory and operational framework, which produced a draft decree, an internal bylaw and an operations guide.

Sectoral work is further on in places. A national digital-transformation strategy for technical and vocational education was officially validated at a CFEN workshop on 6 November 2025, while the National Land Policy remained a draft after its validation workshop in Tadjourah on 6–7 December 2025 and a national carbon-market framework was tabled for validation in August 2026 after an Agence souveraine carbone had already been given a director-general. On the machinery of government, Djibouti launched the PAGEF public governance reform programme on 11 June 2026 with USD 20 million, and it scores 43.1 out of 100 for Overall Governance in the 2024 Ibrahim Index, 38th of 54 African states and below the African average of 49.3, improving 3.9 points over 2014-2023 at a pace that has slowed since 2019.

Most of the digital strategy instruments sitting beneath Vision 2035 are at consultation, validation or revision stage rather than in force.

Legislation and regulation

Djibouti gained a second framework digital statute within six months of the first: the [Startup Act, Loi n° 179/AN/25/9ème L](#), was adopted on 12 November 2025, signed on 1 December and published in the [Journal Officiel](#) of 15 December 2025, taking effect from promulgation under article 35. It writes a [Startup Visa](#) into primary law, a three-year renewable residence-card category for founders and their employees that carries an automatic work permit, and provides for a regulatory sandbox run under the [Haut Conseil Supérieur de l'Économie Numérique et de l'Innovation](#), a body created by the 2022 law founding the delegate ministry for the digital economy and innovation.

The [Code du numérique](#) behind it was adopted on 30 June 2025, promulgated by President [Ismail Omar Guelleh](#) on 6 July and published in the [Journal Officiel](#) of 18 September 2025. It runs to eight books and nearly 800 articles, covering personal data protection, electronic communication, cryptology, e-commerce, consumer rights, cybersecurity and cybercrime, and innovative digital services, and contains no artificial-intelligence-specific provision, so AI is reached by law only indirectly, through the data protection, electronic communications and cybercrime rules.

What the statute book still does not do is compel interoperability: no binding law requires [Djiboutian](#) ministries to connect to the national data exchange platform, which the [World Bank](#) identifies as the reason adoption has stayed limited. Much of the running is made by decree and by the annual budget instead. [Décret n° 2026-105/PRE](#) of 11 June 2026 assigns the Justice ministry, with MDENI, to implement the digitalisation of legal services, and the 2026 finance law imposes ten-year retention of trade transaction records and a cash-declaration threshold of 1,000,000 [Djiboutian francs](#) while creating a two-stage administrative appeal against customs decisions and binding twelve-month advance rulings on classification, origin and valuation. Telecommunications sit outside that momentum: [Djibouti Telecom](#) remains a statutory monopoly under [loi 13/1998](#) and [loi 80/2004](#).

Older law still shapes what can be digitised at all: rural policing falls to the [National Gendarmerie](#), which is legally required to keep [procès-verbaux](#) and [garde-à-vue](#) custody registers by hand.

Data protection

Djibouti's data-protection regime has been law for a year without a regulator to apply it: the [Digital Code](#) designates a [National Commission for the Protection of Personal Data](#) as supervisory authority with administrative and financial autonomy, but as of late 2025 the commission had not been operationally established, leaving the regime without an enforcement body.

The regime it would enforce is substantial. The 156-article regime is modelled on the [GDPR](#), granting rights of access, rectification, erasure and portability exercisable free of charge, requiring controllers to notify the authority of a breach within 72 hours and affected individuals without undue delay where the risk is high, and making failure to notify a criminal offence. It also requires controllers to appoint data protection officers and provides for a public register of processing operations, and operates a tiered prior-authorisation regime under which higher-risk processing — biometric and genetic identity data, and processing that uses the national identifier — must be authorised before it begins. Because any processing involving the national identification number needs prior authorisation from the commission, the country's mobile identity programme falls in the highest-scrutiny tier. On cross-border movement, articles 99-103 regulate international transfers through adequacy findings or authorisation and impose no blanket domestic-storage requirement; the promulgated text carrying Book I on personal data protection is the [Journal Officiel](#) special issue of 18 September 2025.

Practice is running ahead of the regulator. Officers of the [Police Nationale](#) and the road-safety police in central [Djibouti](#) carry body-worn cameras as routine standard issue rather than as a pilot, under protocols requiring the device to be worn visibly and the subject to be told they are being recorded, with recording triggered either manually

or automatically according to the type of intervention or the threat level detected. Elsewhere, co-design workshops in October 2025 for a digital agricultural advisory service wrote their own data-governance framework covering traceability, user feedback and data protection.

Cross-border rules are being written regionally. A July 2025 Horn of Africa Initiative ministerial meeting called on IGAD and the East African Community to pilot a trusted cross-border personal-data-flow mechanism within twelve months, and Djibouti's own seat in that work is as an IGAD member state in the East African Community's Technical Working Group on Data Protection and Cross-Border Data, rather than as a lead or host.

Regional collaboration

Djibouti holds one of the region's digital institutions on its own soil: the Project Implementation Unit for Phase I of IGAD's Horn of Africa Digital Market Integration project is based in the country, which in May 2026 opened a call for in-country training and mentorship of women- and youth-led MSMEs in gender-sensitive digital trade for delivery between June and December 2026.

On data governance the country is a participant rather than a convener. Its national data-policy context was mapped against the African Union Data Policy Framework and the Smart Africa Data Governance Blueprint at a regional workshop in Nairobi on 9-11 June 2026, which applied UNESCO's Data Governance Toolkit to draft regional harmonisation roadmaps, alongside Burundi, Ethiopia, Kenya, Somalia, South Sudan, Tanzania and Uganda. Health data is the strand with an actual instrument behind it: IGAD's Regional Health Data Sharing and Protection Policy Framework of June 2022 gives member states including Djibouti non-binding guidance on protected cross-border sharing, and draws on the African Union Convention on Cyber Security and Personal Data Protection and on the ECOWAS and SADC model instruments. The health ministry also joined IGAD's second ministerial meeting on pandemic preparedness in Kampala on 29 August 2025, whose communiqué commits member states to real-time cross-border data sharing and to interoperability of surveillance data across national boundaries.

Djibouti hosted two regional digital-policy convenings on its own territory within three months, an IGAD cyber-resilience workshop at Arta in October 2025 and the African Union's 16th Private Sector Forum in December 2025.

That December 2025 forum ran on the theme of harnessing Africa's digital economy and innovation to accelerate intra-African trade. Beyond the Horn, Djibouti sits on the Dar es Salaam–Nairobi–Addis Ababa–Berbera–Djibouti corridor, one of eleven strategic corridors announced at the February 2022 EU–African Union summit under the Global Gateway package, though that assessment carries no funding decision and is meant only to help financiers prioritise where to invest next. Regional payments rules covering the country are commissioned but not written, and the cross-border fibre corridors the government leans on are agreements rather than infrastructure in service. Ministerial energy goes largely into courting partners: the communications minister took the digital-administration agenda to the WSIS Forum in Geneva in July 2026, seeking ITU and Smart Africa cooperation on digitising public services. Djibouti scores 56.3 out of 100 on Regional Integration in the Ibrahim Index in 2023, 16th of 54 African states and up 10.0 points over 2014-2023.

Standards

Djibouti's standards body began producing standing machinery in 2025: the Agence Djiboutienne des Normes et de la Qualité brought two Comités Techniques de Normalisation into operation during the year, covering agri-food and electrical, electrotechnical and household appliance standards. Its 2026 provisional budget was approved at 134.9 million Djiboutian francs on 13 January 2026, up from 112.1 million in 2025, of which 54.4 million is investment earmarked for laboratory equipment, software and instrumentation. The agency was founded by Loi n° 100/AN/

20/8ème L of 7 January 2021 and organised by decree in May 2022 as the national reference body for standardisation, metrology, certification, accreditation and quality promotion, under the Ministry of Commerce and Tourism.

Radio spectrum is the gap. There is no adopted national spectrum plan: the regulator ARMD and the ITU held a workshop on 9-10 November 2025 on spectrum-management strategy and regulation, feeding a forthcoming National Spectrum Management Plan covering licensing, pricing and sharing.

For public-sector data the reference document is ANSIE's *Cadre d'Interopérabilité*, which defines interoperability principles, four layers — legal, organisational, semantic and technical — and a conceptual model for the country's e-government architecture; ANSIE is its designated owner, the framework being mandated under Vision Djibouti 2035's "Bonne Gouvernance" pillar and the 2020–2022 e-government strategy. Sector-specific technical norms are set by regulators rather than by the standards agency: the central bank has enforced cheque conformity to SYRAD platform standards by communiqué under the 2016 payment-systems statute, and the composition of the national identification number is fixed by decree. The Code du numérique of 2025 is the framework instrument above all of it, covering data protection, electronic communications, cybersecurity and cybercrime, and digital services.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

Djibouti's Digital Freedom score in the Ibrahim Index fell 17.0 points over 2014-2023 to 24.6 out of 100, 46th of 54 African states — the third most deteriorated of the country's 96 indicators, and a decline running against its rising infrastructure scores. The wider civic picture is of the same shape: Rights is the second worst of the country's sub-categories at 24.7 out of 100 in 2023, 49th of 54, with Media Freedom at 22.0 offsetting a 12.5-point rise in Freedom of Expression and Belief to 44.8, and Freedom of Association and Assembly scores 0.0, unchanged across the whole decade. Freedom House scores the country 24 out of 100 and rates government openness and transparency at the lowest available level, and the media and information regime is still governed solely by Loi n° 2/AN/92/2ème L of 15 September 1992, never substantially reformed in over three decades.

Consultation on digital policy does happen, and the AI strategy is where it has been widest. The workshop of 22 January 2026 drew roughly 80 participants from government, UN agencies, academia, the private sector and civil society, using UNESCO's five-dimension readiness methodology as its diagnostic instrument; the week of bilateral meetings before it surfaced uneven national awareness, varying institutional capacity and outright resistance among some stakeholders. The national development plan was formulated through a five-region, three-week consultation in which each region had to produce a validated contribution report drawing in elected officials, local authorities, civil society and experts.

Where the Digital Code is concerned, the engagement came after the fact: MDENI presented the Code to the France-Djibouti Business Group's General Assembly on 6 November 2025, five months after the text became law, making its data-protection and e-commerce provisions the parts first explained to an external audience. Transparency instruments are newer still: the PAGEF programme introduces the country's first Budget Citoyen alongside strengthened control and accountability mechanisms, and Djibouti has no dedicated access-to-information statute even though the Code du numérique establishes a right of access to administrative documents and the reuse of public data and requires an annual open-data catalogue.

Public participation in digital policymaking rests on a handful of dated events between April 2022 and February 2026, only some of which put a text to non-state participants before it was settled.

Finance

MoUs and other agreements

Djibouti's largest digital agreement has so far produced nothing on the ground: the [memorandum of understanding signed with China's LinkWise Group on 19 July 2026](#), stated at US\$1.35 billion for a 100 MW artificial-intelligence compute centre, up to 500 MW of solar, wind and storage generation, a digital industrial park and international data corridors, is valid for one year, with phase one due within three years of its conditions being met. It is [the largest single digital commitment on the country's record, carried entirely by the investors, with no state equity and no sovereign debt](#).

The [terms the signing minister has set out](#) run to a dedicated artificial-intelligence special economic zone financed by two Shanghai companies, with a policy-stability clause and a tax-exemption period.

Fourteen commitments are on the record, announced between June 2014 and July 2026, and that single unclosed memorandum is worth roughly four times all the finance actually committed to Djibouti's digital sector put together (as at September 2026).

Two instruments have gone further. The [Horizon Fiber arrangement](#) between Djibouti Telecom, Ethio telecom and Sudatel began as a memorandum of understanding and became a binding agreement in February 2026, covering a [cross-border build with Ethiopia and Sudan](#). Italy's [Fondazione Med-Or has signed a memorandum with the Ministry of Economy and Finance](#) covering critical infrastructure, digital connectivity and strategic dialogue, under which it is [building Djiboutian capacity to inspect and protect submarine cables at the landing station](#).

The rest sit where LinkWise sits. The [Smart Wallet memorandum signed with Visa](#) in September 2025 has produced no rollout calendar, budget or vendor contract; the European Investment Bank and Sparkle [formalised their collaboration on the Blue Raman cable](#) in October 2025; and [Djibouti and Romania opened a bilateral digital cooperation track](#) in September 2025.

Across the record as a whole the financing arrives as debt rather than grant: seven of the fourteen commitments are concessional loans and three are commercial, against two grants, one technical-assistance package and a single memorandum of understanding (as at September 2026).

New investments

Only six of the fourteen digital commitments on Djibouti's record were still active as at September 2026, worth about US\$162 million; six had closed, one was approved without disbursing and one stood at pipeline stage.

Djibouti's largest live World Bank operation is the [Integrated Slum Upgrading Project](#), US\$50 million in IDA credits and grants, whose additional financing was extended in December 2025 to a close of 31 December 2026 disbursement then standing at 68 per cent; its digital content is the registration of refugee and host communities. The [Integrated Community Resilience Project](#), an SDR 23.8 million grant (about US\$31 million) approved in March 2025, puts US\$15 million into scaling the national Social Registry and its interoperability with the identity agency ANSIE; the [Economic and Financial Governance Project](#) lends US\$20 million over 2025 to 2030 for tax administration and financial management systems; and the [Digital Foundations Project](#) carries US\$10 million to open ICT to competition.

The World Bank holds seven of the fourteen commitments and about US\$173 million, roughly half of all committed finance once the unclosed memorandum is set aside; the Islamic Development Bank follows with two submarine-cable loans (as at September 2026).

Before that the money went into cable: [US\\$17 million for the AAE-1 connection](#) over 2015 to 2017 and [US\\$39 million for DARE-1](#) closed in 2021, both commercial loans from the Islamic Development Bank. The closed [Public Administration Modernization Project](#), SDR 10.4 million approved in 2018, funded an interoperable government platform, a national CERT and a public key infrastructure; the [Agence Française de Développement](#) has lent EUR 10 million (about US\$11 million) for 2020 to 2027 to digitalise higher education; and the EU and Germany's [D4D initiative for digital government and cybersecurity](#), EUR 3 million across Kenya, Somalia and Djibouti, closed in 2025.

One commercial commitment sits outside all of this: [Rand Merchant Bank's US\\$60 million for the data-centre operator Wingu Africa](#), a facility spanning three countries (June 2025).

Connectivity is where the money has gone, three commitments worth about US\$66 million, with roughly US\$117 million to government systems across registries, public financial management and payments; the much larger data-storage total is almost all unclosed pipeline (as at September 2026).

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

Djibouti's regulator [granted NetCatOnline SAS an authorisation on 22 March 2026](#) to build and operate a national wired electronic-communications network, to sell internet access and private data transmission, and to reach Djibouti Telecom's cable-landing stations — the first such permission issued in a market where [Djibouti Telecom is the sole operator](#).

The international position remains the country's strongest asset. [The Prime Minister put the count at fourteen submarine-cable landings on 1 March 2026](#), with Google's Blue Raman described as coming soon rather than counted in the total. [That system, 11,700 km landing in Djibouti, India and Oman](#), was presented by the European Commission in October 2025 as the physical layer of an EU–Africa–India Digital Corridor and a deliverable under the India–Middle East–Europe Economic Corridor.

Two cross-border fibre builds are in train. [Djibouti Telecom, Ethio telecom and Sudatel signed a binding tripartite agreement on 4 February 2026](#) for the Horizon Fiber corridor, linking Djibouti's and Sudan's landing stations through Ethiopia and [specified at roughly 2,800 km with 144 fibre pairs and about 14 ms latency](#). Separately, [Djibouti Telecom is extending DARE1 south from Kenya toward South Africa, a segment specified at 36 Tbit/s over some 3,200–3,500 km with a 2028 in-service target](#).

Both of the cross-border fibre projects Djibouti has joined are running in parallel, and neither has been confirmed complete.

Domestically, [internet users reached 65.30% of the population in 2024](#), from 59.93% in 2020. The country ranks ninth of 54 African states on the Ibrahim Index's internet and computers measure, at 61.2 out of 100 in 2023, and forty-sixth on mobile communications, at 47.3. [AMS-IX Djibouti extends the country's existing DjIX exchange](#). No national spectrum management plan has been adopted, and the universal service fund meant to subsidise equitable access is still at design stage.

Data Storage

Djibouti's largest storage prospect exists on paper only. In July 2026 the government agreed terms for an artificial-intelligence compute zone with a Chinese investor, [offering land and guaranteed seawater abstraction rights for cooling, a policy-stability clause, a tax-exemption period, and technical training in place of local employment quotas](#), all of it inside a memorandum of understanding rather than a signed investment protocol.

What is on the ground is smaller and largely commercial. Wingu Africa's TO7 — a Tier-3 carrier-neutral data centre combined with a submarine cable landing station and an innovation centre, the first integrated facility of its kind in the country — was inaugurated on 25 November 2024. Its Technology Park facility carries 3MW and certified Tier III status, alongside the Djibouti Data Center established in 2013. The operator also sells infrastructure-as-a-service, containers-as-a-service and satellite teleport services from its Djibouti estate, and raised US\$60m from Rand Merchant Bank in June 2025 to expand across Djibouti, Ethiopia and Tanzania. PAIX Data Centres and the sovereign Fonds Souverain de Djibouti announced a joint venture in May 2024 to build a further carrier-neutral facility, JIB1.

On the state side, the World Bank's May 2024 digital-economy diagnostic recorded a fully operational central-government data centre, with many public entities still hosted on separate infrastructure of their own. The primary National Payment System data centre was established under a World Bank project that closed on 30 June 2021, which also financed a US\$50,000 contract with Djibouti Telecom for a disaster-recovery back-up site. The Secretariat-General of the Government and the UNDP signed a letter of accord on 2 August 2026 to digitise the state's archives, with secure backup of the data hosted at the ANSIE data centre.

Policy has not caught up with either. No sovereign-cloud strategy has been adopted: the Smart Nation roadmap's sovereign cloud project begins with defining a national cloud framework, a step still to be taken as at May 2024. The Digital Code restricts cross-border transfers of personal data to jurisdictions offering adequate protection, but imposes no blanket requirement to store personal or government data in-country.

Energy

Djibouti's government validated a national energy pact on 25 May 2026 setting a target of 60% rural electricity access by 2030 and universal access by 2035, against a rural access rate of 17.8% and close to 30% of the population unserved. The investment it says this needs is US\$1.745bn, of which over US\$728m is sought from the private sector.

The supply that exists is mostly someone else's. Around 65.2% of the population had access to electricity in 2023, and roughly 65% of supply is imported from Ethiopia with about 20% coming from the 60MW Ghoubet wind farm (2025). The second Ethiopia–Djibouti interconnection, the transmission capacity intended to reduce that single-supplier exposure, was behind schedule as at November 2025, though the contract for its 230kV double-circuit line from Semera substation to Galafi was awarded on 24 November 2025. Grid reliability was 9.37 hours of interruption per customer in 2022, against a target of 7 hours by 2027, and residential tariffs are among the highest in Africa.

Off-grid delivery is at pilot scale. A 165kW off-grid solar plant with 500kWh of battery storage was inaugurated at Adailou in Tadjourah in September 2025, giving electricity for the first time to roughly 100 households along with schools, health facilities and businesses. Japan funded and the UNDP launched a US\$373,333 twelve-month solar pilot on 21 April 2026 at Yoboki in Dikhil and Omar Jaggaa in Arta, pairing electricity with water access and community maintenance. Rural electricity access is itself a constraint on integrating schools into the national education management information system (April 2025), and the country scores 37.1 out of 100 on the Ibrahim Index's access to energy measure in 2023, 29th of 54 African states.

Rural access is 42.2 percentage points short of the pact's own 2030 target. The 500 MW of generation pledged to the single artificial-intelligence compute project announced in July 2026 is about three thousand times the capacity of the Adailou plant, and the US\$1.35bn behind that project is roughly 77% of the entire investment the pact says universal access requires.

Technical Capacity

The World Bank's June 2025 completion report on Djibouti's Public Administration Modernization Project names local capacity as the persistent constraint on the interoperable platform it financed: limited familiarity with complex IT contracts, difficulty retaining technical consultants, and weak supervision of international vendors.

The government's own reading is not far off. A cross-ministry digital-maturity diagnostic presented to the Council of Ministers on 7 October 2025 found the administration fragmented and unevenly equipped, and the bilateral meetings preceding the January 2026 national AI strategy workshop surfaced uneven awareness, varying institutional capacity and outright resistance among some stakeholders.

Institution-building is where the movement is. The new cybersecurity authority was assembled around ANSIE's existing information systems security directorate rather than started from nothing. A dedicated civil-service corps for the statistics institute's staff — statistical engineers, senior administrators and senior technicians — was created by decree published on 12 May 2026, and technical assistance is strengthening INSTAD's own capacity to collect sensitive population data. A digital-skills training programme for civil servants runs with the Digital Cooperation Organization, Oracle University and the national public administration institute.

Further down the system, capacity arrives as donated equipment on borrowed terms. Djibouti's STEM centres run on a split model in which STEMpower supplies the equipment and the initial training while the education ministry and host schools provide premises and ongoing upkeep. The GOSE education management information system has been rolled out nationally to all public primary schools (February 2026). IGAD handed over digital equipment to district health offices and health information system units in December 2024, strengthening the health information system at district and regional level rather than at the clinic. The standards agency brought two technical standardisation committees into operation during 2025.

Cybersecurity

Loi n° 195/AN/25/9ème L, published in the Journal Officiel on 15 December 2025, creates the Autorité Nationale de Cybersécurité as an autonomous public establishment under the Presidency, built around ANSIE's existing information systems security directorate. The Council of Ministers had approved the bill on 4 November 2025 and appointed the authority's director-general on 18 November 2025; it stood up in December 2025.

The authority follows a strategy and a code rather than preceding them. A National Cybersecurity Strategy for 2024–2030, built on five pillars, was unveiled in December 2024. The Code du numérique's cybersecurity and data-protection provisions became citable by article when it was published in the Journal Officiel on 18 September 2025, and operationalising its telecommunications and cybersecurity books is what the pending revision of the Smart Nation Strategy prioritises.

Capability lags the instruments. Djibouti scores 31.48 out of 100 on the ITU's Global Cybersecurity Index, in its evolving band (2024). The government's own October 2025 digital-maturity diagnostic still lists a cybersecurity policy among the instruments the Code enables but that remain outstanding. A national computer emergency response team and a public key infrastructure were delivered under the now-closed Public Administration Modernization Project.

Physical protection of the cables the economy rests on is being built by others. Italy's foreign ministry and Fondazione Med-Or run a project at Djibouti's submarine-cable landing station, under a memorandum of understanding with the finance ministry, to strengthen the Djiboutian authorities' own capability to inspect and

protect that infrastructure. Regionally, Djibouti hosted IGAD's cyber-resilience workshop at Arta on 6–8 October 2025, whose purpose was consultation on a regional information sharing and analysis centre still at the stakeholder stage.

DPI

Data Exchange

Djibouti's national data exchange has been built and is not being used for its purpose: a World Bank evaluation in June 2025 found that the administrations connected to the interoperability platform [do not exchange information with one another through it](#), continuing instead down bilateral, non-automated channels. [Ten government systems were technically connected in 2025](#) — the national population register, the social registry and its collections-and-benefits system and the ASYCUDAWorld customs system among them — while the justice, education, health, employment, passport and electoral systems were not.

The platform is an X-Road installation known as Caravan, [completed at the end of 2021 with Estonia's e-Governance Academy and managed by ANSIE](#), the state information-systems agency. Nothing compels a ministry to join it: [no binding law requires connection](#), which the World Bank treats as the reason adoption has stayed limited, even though the 2019 identification law had already [made the national identification number obligatory for exchanging data between public and parapublic services](#) and a 2022 statute charges the digital economy ministry MDENI with [breaking down ministerial application silos and ensuring interoperability by design](#).

The current build is the World Bank's Digital Foundations Project, whose pilot had [connected 33 ministries, departments and agencies to national platforms by February 2026, 11 in Djibouti city and 22 in the regions](#); the generalisation phase beyond it is [much larger and carries no date, cost or sequencing](#). Five months after the Mobile ID launch the Direction générale de la Population et de la Famille described its own interoperability layer — real-time verification of the identity card for other administrations, banks and social-protection bodies — as [still in preparation \(July 2026\)](#).

Statute keeps running ahead of practice: the 2026 finance law [requires the customs and treasury information systems to be interconnected](#), with daily and monthly reconciliation of fiscal and non-fiscal revenue, and [constitutes the Sydonia World clearance system as an electronic single window](#) centralising declarations, certificates of origin, licences, freight manifests, inspection results and sanitary and phytosanitary certificates.

Digital Identity and CRVS

The Ministry of the Interior [launched a Mobile ID credential on 10 February 2026](#), and its design keeps the biometrics in one pair of hands: [the biometric database is held exclusively by the ministry, other institutions reaching it only through encrypted server-to-server requests rather than by holding copies](#), so that partner administrations [query the authentication service and receive only the result](#). The government puts the same framing to its financiers, describing the work to a World Bank delegation in March 2026 as [sovereignty over citizens' data](#). At the forum that preceded the launch President Ismaïl Omar Guelleh [set the benefits of biometric identity against the risks of identity theft, cloning, hacking, espionage and over-centralisation](#), and called for continuous public vigilance.

At launch the credential [carried authentication for bank account opening, civil registry access, tax filing, building permits and electronic signing of official documents](#), with driving licences and health records planned rather than in place. It is an additional access channel onto the existing national register rather than a replacement for it, and other government systems, driving licences among them, [remain fragmented and unlinked to the national digital identity](#).

The statutory base long predates the app. Law No. 39/AN/19 of 21 January 2019 created the [Registre National des Personnes Physiques](#) and a national identification number assigned to every person from birth, with the physical card issued only from age 18; a 2020 decree fixed the number as a twelve-position code encoding sex, date of birth, a sequence number and a check digit and required it on virtually every official document, from property and hospital records to school, university, utility and commercial ones, telecom subscriber records included. The card is issued for a fee rather than free; foreign nationals residing regularly are eligible for the register while refugee identity cards issued by the national refugee agency ONARS do not carry the number.

Capture at rural civil-registry counters [was not digitised by the 2019 law and remains on paper](#), and a national statistics institute survey activity with the World Bank and UNHCR flags that [digital identification could inadvertently exclude undocumented residents from healthcare and education](#). An earlier attempt was abandoned: the e-ID subcomponent of the World Bank's Public Administration Modernization Project was dropped at the first restructuring on 17 March 2022 and never delivered.

Djibouti took seven years to move from founding identity statute to a live biometric credential: eighteen months from the January 2019 law to the July 2020 decree setting the number's technical specification, and a further five and a half years to Mobile ID's launch in February 2026.

Digital Payments and Fintech

Djibouti is [a live participant in the Pan-African Payment and Settlement System \(2026\)](#), the central bank having linked its settlement system SYRAD to that continental infrastructure and to COMESA's regional system REPSS. Domestically the reach is narrower: AfricaNenda's 2024 review [dropped SYRAD from its landscape of inclusive instant payment systems](#) because it does not meet the definition of a fully operational, inclusive system, and found its governance carries no consumer advisory body, no reserved representation for small payment service providers and no financial inclusion mandate.

SYRAD, a real-time gross settlement system paired with an automated clearing house, [went into service on 15 July 2021](#) with the Treasury as a participant, and the [Banque Centrale de Djibouti owns, oversees and operates it and acts as its settlement agent, reporting its volumes and values annually](#). The statute behind it, [Loi n°118/AN/15/7ème L of 16 July 2016](#), has gone a decade without amendment, so the central bank moves by directive under it — ruling by communiqué in July 2025 that [from 31 August 2025 no cheque failing the new SYRAD format, security and encoding standards would be cleared](#).

Retail use is thin. [Fewer than a third of the population hold a bank account \(2023\)](#), and Access to Banking Services is among [Djibouti's ten worst Ibrahim Index indicators](#), at 10.0 out of 100 in 2023 and 40th of 54 African states. The country's first online payment gateway [opened on 10 December 2023](#), run by the state operator Djibouti Telecom through its D-Money service, which [supports person-to-person transfers and merchant payments](#); [electronic payment has since been introduced for vehicle road tax, stamp duty and licensing fees](#). A national payment gateway for government remains planned and under implementation rather than built.

The most-publicised project is still a memorandum: Djibouti [signed an MoU with Visa on 16 September 2025 to develop a national Smart Wallet](#) combining payments, government services and digital identity, with no rollout calendar, budget or vendor contract announced, designed as [a single digital counter for health, education, tax, social benefits, permits and business formalities](#).

Registries

Djibouti's Social Registry held 515,730 people in February 2025 against a target of 600,000, and the World Bank-financed expansion meant to close that gap had not commenced on data to 31 January 2026. A 2020 decree made the register the sole instrument for targeting beneficiaries of social-protection programmes, and its target population is defined as poor Djiboutian households and the refugee population resident on national territory, so refugee inclusion rests on the legal text rather than on programme practice alone.

Civil registration is where digitisation is thinnest: registrars in the interior regions work from handwritten paper registers and forward statistics physically to the central civil status administration (2024), while Djibouti-Ville has run a computerised civil status system, SIGEC, since 2011 and commissioned an expert diagnostic of it in 2024. The country's Civil Registration score in the Ibrahim Index was 62.5 out of 100 in 2023, 24th of 54 African states, and had not moved at all over the decade. Refugees and asylum seekers have been able to register vital events, births especially, since 2013, though a backlog of unregistered pre-2013 births and access difficulties in refugee-hosting areas persist.

The land register has the strongest legal footing of the lot: the 2018 land-property law gives the centralised scanned and electronic database of land books legal effect as the operative title and requires every private parcel to be mapped and recorded, and obliges the registry to let the public consult it free of charge. Most deed records were computerised or scanned by 2018, sharing a single database and common property identifiers with the cadastral agency, with no electronic database for checking encumbrances and cadastral maps still on paper. The World Bank extended the Integrated Slum Upgrading Project's additional financing by twelve months to 31 December 2026 to complete land-tenure regularisation and resettlement.

The business register, the Registre de Commerce et des Sociétés maintained by ODPIC, is legally mandatory within a month of incorporation and publishes certificates online, though filing still requires attending the one-stop shop in person. For addressing, La Poste de Djibouti adopted what3words as the official national standard in February 2017, assigning a fixed three-word address to every three-metre square of the country.

Sectoral management information systems

Only 37% of Djibouti's health facilities – 23 of 62 – were connected to the national logistics information system at 31 December 2024, against a project target of 65%, while 69% were entering data directly into the DHIS2 health information system on the same date. DHIS2 does not collect at community or primary-clinic level, so rural clinics keep paper registers that are compiled and entered at a higher administrative level. The sector runs DHIS2, SORMAS for disease surveillance and mSupply for pharmaceutical stock, completed nationwide in April 2025, none of them connected to the government's interoperability platform, and WHO's country office recorded in April 2025 that the health information system has limitations, that DHIS2 was under review and that resources were still being sought to revamp it.

Education has gone further: the national education management information system GOSE has been deployed to every public primary school and assigns each pupil a unique student identifier, and the ministry made consolidation of the system through the GOSE and SMIS platforms a strategic priority for 2025-2026, aimed at identifying at-risk pupils and tracking them individually. Routine records lag that architecture: directors enter enrolment and administrative data through the OPAD application, but attendance and grades are still kept mainly on paper and rural schools are constrained by connectivity, electricity and ICT skills. In April 2026 Djibouti became the first country in the world to have 100% of its school locations validated on Giga Maps, after AI identification of school buildings from satellite imagery.

On the revenue side the tax directorate runs a computerised register and administration system, AGIR, and is progressively replacing it with an Integrated Tax Administration System offering electronic filing, declaration and payment, with customs administered separately on ASYCUDAWorld. The gap between the two showed at the close of the World Bank's public administration project, where customs modernisation succeeded while the tax IT system the same project financed remained non-operational. For the state's own payroll, the 2026 finance law requires the Fichier Unique database of state personnel to be updated to take in contract staff and headcounts awaiting regularisation.

The sectoral management information systems now being built in Djibouti — across education, social protection, health, justice, tax and land — are financed by external donor projects rather than from the domestic budget.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

Djibouti counted its public services before digitising them: the digital economy ministry's catalogue, presented to the Council of Ministers on 7 October 2025, inventoried 503 public services — 281 citizen-facing, 187 business-facing and 35 inter-agency — and selected 83 of them for priority digitalisation.

The starting point is low: the UN's E-Government Development Index places Djibouti 174th, in its lowest band with a score below 0.25 (2024), and the Ibrahim Index's Public Administration score reached 47.9 out of 100 in 2023, 31st of 54 African states, with Effective Administration up 12.1 points over the decade to 50.1.

Delivery has lagged the money. The Public Administration Modernization Project disbursed US\$14,152,636 against an original commitment of US\$15,000,000, closing near its full budget despite having shrunk its delivery target — the Citizen Service Center pilot was cut back at the 2022 restructuring. Its successor on public finance had effectiveness pushed to 9 March 2026 by a third extension and its ratings downgraded to Moderately Satisfactory, reporting tax e-filing at 0% against a 70% target set for December 2029, and a public-financial-management reform programme, PAGEF, was launched on 11 June 2026 with components covering tax administration, public expenditure, financial information systems and e-government.

What is running is narrower and mostly transactional. Electronic customs clearance is compulsory under the 2026 annual finance law rather than under a standalone digital-administration statute, on an ASYCUDAWorld installation the World Bank had already written up in January 2024 as a worked example of digitising a core revenue and trade-facilitation function. An online company-creation platform opened in January 2026 as the digital successor to the Guichet unique; La Poste takes online orders for criminal-record extracts and certificates of non-conviction; and the urban rehabilitation agency ARULoS runs E-Doleances, an online complaint portal routing recovery and technical complaints to named internal divisions. On 2 August 2026 the Secrétariat général du Gouvernement and the UNDP signed a letter of accord to dematerialise the state's archives, covering indexing, digitisation, training of a national team and secure backup of the data at the ANSIE data centre.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

Damerjog, in the Arta region, came online in October 2025 under the Djibouti Fondement du Numérique programme, which brought a school of more than 1,200 pupils, a sub-prefecture office and a clinic onto the network. The pilot phase of the World Bank-financed Djibouti Digital Foundations Project has connected ministries, departments and agencies in the regions as well as in the capital (February 2026).

Two-thirds of the agencies connected under that pilot sit outside Djibouti city, so the sub-national reach of the interoperability build is already most of what has been delivered rather than a later phase.

Connection is not yet participation. Djibouti's data exchange remains national-level: central administrations plus an integrated prefecture system for Djibouti-Ville, with no other regional or local government taking part (2025). The capital has run its own computerised civil status management system, SIGEC, since 2011, and the municipality commissioned an international expert diagnostic of it in 2024 with modernisation and data security in view. The World Bank's Public Administration Modernization Project, which closed in 2025, delivered its interoperable digital platform and Citizen Service Center pilot at reduced scope following a 2022 restructuring.

The clearest transfer of a service to an elected sub-national body is not a digital one. Civil-status administration passed from the prefectural administration to the Dikhil Regional Council at a ceremony on 27 April 2026, marked by the opening of a branch office in the sous-préfecture de Mouloud.

Rural digital data capture

Registration reached deeper into rural Dikhil on 27 April 2026, when a civil-status branch office opened in the sous-préfecture de Mouloud. What it extends is a service that, outside the capital, runs on handwritten registers at prefecture-level registrar's offices, with statistics carried physically to the central civil status administration (2024).

Health data capture stops short of the clinic for the same reason. The Ministry of Health's DHIS2 platform collects nothing at community or primary-clinic level, so rural clinics keep paper registers that are compiled and entered higher up the administrative chain (2024). Where fibre has arrived the change is abrupt: more than 200 km deployed under the Djibouti Fondement du Numérique programme reached Ali-Sabieh regional hospital, replacing an inter-hospital medical-record exchange that had taken a whole day with instant sharing (June 2025).

Schools are the one rural network where routine capture is already partly digital. The national education management system has been deployed to every public primary school (April 2025), and since 2024 a tablet-based classroom observation tool has been mandatory nationwide, with pedagogical advisors recording directly into a central dashboard during school visits. Attendance and grades are still kept mainly on paper, and rural schools are further constrained by limited connectivity, electricity and ICT skills (2024).

Agriculture is being designed for the constraint rather than around it. AfDB-supported co-design workshops in Djibouti City on 6–7 October 2025 under the BREFONS programme produced digital advisory services for the Ali-Sabieh and Tadjourah regions, built as interactive voice response scripts, micro-videos, agro-meteorological bulletin templates and community-radio content in Somali and Afar, for low-connectivity, mixed-literacy rural users.

The governance measures behind all of this move in opposite directions. Rural Market Access fell 6.3 points over 2014–2023 to 9.4 out of 100, 37th of 54 African states and among Djibouti's ten worst-scoring indicators in the Ibrahim Index, even as the Rural Economy score rose 8.7 points to 45.9 (2023). Rural Representation and Participation is the country's fifth most improved indicator, up 22.8 points to 49.5, and Rural Land and Water Access rose 14.4 points to 73.3, eleventh of 54 (2023).

Technology

AI

No Djiboutian law addresses artificial intelligence directly, on the telecommunications regulator's own account, and the national strategy meant to set the direction had its main lines presented on 3 September 2026 at the country's first national AI forum, covering 2026 to 2030 around six priorities - data and AI governance, cybersecurity, training, research, innovation and inclusion - with tools working in Somali, Afar and Arabic named as the means of limiting a new digital divide. No text is published.

Drafting ran through 2026 with [UN-ESCWA](#) and [UNESCO](#) support, public institutions being consulted at a workshop in Djibouti on 22 January 2026. The week of bilateral meetings that preceded it [found uneven awareness of AI across institutions, uneven capacity to act on it, and resistance among some of those consulted](#).

The national diagnostic behind the strategy, run on UNESCO's readiness methodology, [placed Djibouti at an emergent stage, with none of its five dimensions — legal, social and cultural, scientific and educational, economic, and technical and infrastructural — rated better than medium](#) (August 2026).

What is actually running is narrow and sits in one sector. [The AI applications the government names in operation run through the port, the Djibouti Ports Community System and Corridor Vision AI among them, and no AI capability is built into the national data exchange](#) (January 2026). The most consequential AI system on the ground reached the country outside the strategy process altogether: a [Chinese-donated meteorological platform generating port- and airport-facing hazard alerts](#), handed over in July 2026 as a donation with no published governance terms. The compute centre announced with Shanghai investors the same month is [a memorandum under which nothing has been built](#), valid for one year.

The domestic base for any of this is small. The [Université de Djibouti opened its first master's degree in artificial intelligence and data modelling in September 2025](#), and dedicated AI teaching and research in the country amounts to little more than that degree as at August 2026.

ICT Industry

Djibouti Telecom's [statutory monopoly](#) acquired its first authorised competitor on 22 March 2026, when the regulator [cleared a private operator to build and run a national wired network, sell internet access and reach the cable landing stations](#).

On the industry's own side, [Djiboutian digital businesses were organising a national federation of digital enterprises as at December 2025](#), intended as a founding member of the African federation set up under the Marrakech Declaration.

Government demand is being reorganised around the sector rather than expanded into it. The ministry responsible for ICT [began designing a government-to-business one-stop platform for small and medium enterprises in December 2025](#), alongside e-procurement work; [company registration is already centralised and legally compulsory](#), though filing still means attending the one-stop shop in person. The digital lines of the [European Union's 2021-2027 country programme](#) run to enterprise digital capacity, women's economic leadership in digital trade and digital skills.

Abroad, the sector is the pitch: the digital economy minister [presented Djibouti to China Exim Bank in Beijing in June 2026 as an emerging platform for artificial intelligence and digital innovation](#), part of an industrial roadmap with China.

Innovation ecosystem

Djibouti's Startup Act, [in force since its promulgation in December 2025](#), creates a state "Startup" label awarded by a [Collège des Startups](#), with a single Startup Djibouti portal as the sole channel for applications.

The gate is narrow. [A company must be under seven years old, built on technological innovation, with more than half its capital held by natural persons or seed investors, and it pays no dividends while it holds the label](#). What it buys is chiefly at the border: [a simplified customs regime for imports used in research and development, prototyping and production](#). The same law also carries a [renewable startup visa](#), a [regulatory sandbox](#) and [state-backed investment vehicles including a fund of funds and a crowdfunding regime](#).

The institutions the law will work through are few. Two hubs carry the ecosystem: CTID, the country's first incubator, established in 2017 and still running entrepreneurship events and training cohorts, and Startup Djibouti, a government-backed accelerator offering incubation, acceleration and grant funding (2024). To those the state added LIMO in July 2026, a platform meant to route startups, developers and entrepreneurs towards support mechanisms, and a tuition-free École 42 coding school launched in April 2026 with the European Union, Expertise France and Association 42.

Home-grown firms are visible but few and small: one Djiboutian company was running a marketplace and delivery service across merchants, restaurants and pharmacies in June 2026, settling in cash on delivery and selected mobile money. Donor programmes supply much of the rest of the pipeline, among them digital agricultural advisory services designed for Ali-Sabieh and Tadjourah at workshops in October 2025 under an African Development Bank programme. The framing goes back to the Digital Economy and Innovation Roadmap launched in April 2022, which set out digital economic transformation, digital administration, sectors and professions of the future, and citizen participation.

Capacity

Literacy

Djibouti ranks 5th of 54 African states for Human Resources in Education in the Ibrahim Index, scoring 96.1 out of 100 in 2023 after a 12.8-point rise, and its Education Quality score rose 16.7 points over the same window to 50.0, 19th of 54 (2023). Enrolment is where the record breaks: Education Enrolment stands at 29.2, 43rd of 54 (2023), the country's weakest education measure despite a 6.0-point gain, while the overall Education score is up 10.0 points across 2014-2023 to 54.2, 25th of 54. Staffing has improved far faster than the number of children reached.

Digital provision inside schools is new and small. Two STEM centres opened in September 2025, at the Lycée de Djibouti and the Lycée de Hodane, each equipped with computer and electronics laboratories and staffed with dedicated mentors.

Routine school records remain largely on paper. Primary school directors enter enrolment and administrative data directly into the OPAD decision-support application, but attendance and grades are still kept mainly on paper and rural schools are further constrained by limited connectivity, electricity and ICT skills (2024); the education ministry is developing an education management information system with a unique student identification number to follow learners through their school career (2025). Where services are designed for people who read little, the pattern is voice and radio rather than text: agricultural advisory content in Somali and Afar is being built as interactive voice response scripts, micro-videos, agro-meteorological bulletins and community-radio material for low-connectivity, mixed-literacy rural users (October 2025).

Training and skills

The World Bank-supported SKILLS Project had trained around 1,500 people by April 2026, across logistics, construction, energy, hospitality, big data and cybersecurity, and sixteen of its candidates had been placed in employment in Canada by then, with Gulf Cooperation Council placements under discussion. Its courses are market-demand-driven and co-designed with employers, and it is run with the ministries of education and labour rather than MENFOP alone.

E-SKILLS, worth EUR 7m over four years and implemented by Expertise France with Djibouti's digital ministry, was launched on 24 November 2025 and targets over 3,000 young people and women by 2029 through Campus 42 Djibouti and regional Maisons du Numérique; its Digital Houses are to establish training centres in five inland regions (May 2026). École 42, a tuition-free peer-learning coding school, has been launched with the European Union, Expertise France and Association 42 (April 2026).

Short cohorts are most of what has been delivered. 240 young Djiboutians completed MENFOP's D-CLIC training in cybersecurity, mobile development and web development, at a closing ceremony on 21 October 2025; a civil-service digital-skills programme runs with the Digital Cooperation Organization, Oracle University and the administration institute INAP (February 2025); and IGAD, whose implementation unit sits in Djibouti, opened a call in May 2026 for digital-trade training and mentorship for women- and youth-led MSMEs, to run from June to December 2026.

The EFTP digital-transformation strategy, developed from 28 May 2025 with OIF/IFEF support, proposes an action programme built around digital tools in learning, graduate tracking and job placement. School-level provision is exposed on recurrent cost: the STEM centres run on a split model, STEMpower supplying equipment and initial training, MENFOP and the host schools the premises and upkeep. The binding constraint may not be training: much of the unemployed already hold an upper-secondary or tertiary qualification, in a majority-informal job market (2025).

Three digital-skills instruments — E-SKILLS, IGAD's digital-trade training call and the SKILLS Project — all name women and youth as target populations, and only one has reported any outcome figure against its own target (May 2026).

Research institutions

Djibouti's research connectivity is being arranged at corridor level: the memorandum accompanying the EU-Africa-India Digital Corridor pairs Europe's GEANT research network with India's National Knowledge Network and Africa's UbuntuNet Alliance for research and education connectivity (October 2025).

The domestic base is institutional rather than large. The Centre d'Étude et de Recherche de Djibouti is the principal data user of the national space programme HYDROSAT, which flies two 1U CubeSats supervised by MENSUR through the Agence Spatiale Djiboutienne, and the engineering base for it was built by ten Djiboutian students trained at the Centre Spatial Universitaire de Montpellier. CRIPEN, the educational research and production institution, is attached directly to the education ministry under the 2024 reorganisation law.

University research capacity in digital fields is being built from a low base and with external money: the Université de Djibouti opened its first master's in artificial intelligence and data modelling in September 2025, and the digitalisation and professionalisation of higher education is financed on concessional terms through to 2027. Academics were among the constituencies at the January 2026 consultation on a national AI strategy, and Italy's minister for universities and research visited Djibouti's submarine-cable landing station in August 2026.

Inclusion

Access to services

51.8% of Djibouti's working-age population was outside the labour force altogether in 2025, and 46.2% of 16-24-year-olds were not in employment, education or training. 40.3% of the unemployed already held an upper-secondary or tertiary qualification (2025), which points at a shortage of jobs rather than of schooling. On the first results of the

2025 EDST labour force survey, 77.9% of private-sector jobs are informal, and employment in Djibouti City is concentrated in services at 70.4% (2025), while the economy outside the capital is more mixed, agriculture accounting for 17.1% of employment.

The gate to most services is the identity card. It is legally required proof of identity and a prerequisite for voter registration, passports, government benefits, employment and school enrolment, so people without a valid card, particularly parts of the nomadic population, risk exclusion from them, and issuance is fee-based rather than free, on tariffs set by decree. Refugee cards issued by the national refugee agency ONARS carry no National Identification Number, and a survey activity run with the national statistics institute, IOM and UNHCR flags that the country's digital identification systems could inadvertently exclude undocumented residents from healthcare and education. Against that, refugees and asylum seekers have been able to register births since 2013, though a backlog of unregistered pre-2013 births and access difficulties in refugee-hosting areas persist, and the Social Registry's own decree names the refugee population resident on national territory in its target group, so refugee inclusion rests on legal text rather than on programme practice alone.

Physical reach extends one office at a time: a civil-status branch opened in the sous-préfecture de Mouloud on 27 April 2026, in a rural part of the Dikhil region, while the Universal Service Fund for equitable access to communications remains at design stage (April 2026). Online, the public can order a criminal record extract from La Poste, register a company on a platform launched in January 2026 and file complaints to the housing agency through its E-Doléances portal. On land, the validation workshop for the draft National Land Policy in December 2025 addressed access for women, youth and vulnerable groups.

Digital divides

Djibouti reaches the African top ten on the Ibrahim Index's Internet & Computers measure, at 61.2 out of 100 in 2023 and 9th of 54 states after a 27.4-point rise over the decade, one of only two indicators on which it does so; Access to Banking Services, at 10.0 out of 100 in the same year and 40th of 54, is among its ten worst-scoring indicators, having gained 4.8 points over 2014-2023. Connectivity is not the binding constraint on who participates.

The measures of how evenly the country's institutions reach people have barely moved. Equal Access to Public Services stood at 30.5 out of 100 in 2023, 37th of 54, and Equal Socioeconomic Opportunity at 35.8, 38th, both having shifted less than three points over the decade. Rural Market Access went backwards, falling 6.3 points to 9.4 and 37th of 54 — likewise one of the ten worst — while the broader Rural Economy score rose 8.7 points to 45.9, 38th of 54. Education rose 10.0 points to 54.2 and 25th of 54, but Education Enrolment remains the weakest of its education measures at 29.2, 43rd of 54, and the urban-rural gap in electricity access (2023) sits underneath all of it.

What is being spent is aimed at the geography rather than at the groups. Fibre laid under the Djibouti Fondement du Numérique programme reached Ali-Sabieh regional hospital by June 2025, replacing a day-long inter-hospital exchange of medical records with instant sharing, and the E-SKILLS "Digital Houses" initiative is establishing digital training centres in five inland regions. At a ministerial meeting in Geneva on 8 July 2026 the government presented that build-out, with the regional EARDIP project, as reducing the domestic digital divide while positioning Djibouti as an East African connectivity hub, the same month it set out a vision of inclusive digital development resting on its submarine-cable position.

Data

National statistics

INSTAD ran Djibouti's [first nationally representative labour force survey, the EDST, in 2025](#), a survey type the World Bank's Statistical Performance Indicators recorded as [missing from the previous decade, alongside agricultural and business surveys](#), as late as 2023. The [third general population and housing census was conducted in 2024](#), fifteen years after the census of 2009, with definitive results issued through UNFPA Djibouti in 2026. INSTAD published a [geocoded national directory of localities and resident populations on 18 November 2025](#), and [launched fieldwork for the seventh Multiple Indicator Cluster Survey on 31 December 2025](#).

The weakness sits upstream. On the same 2023 indicators Djibouti scores [below 20% on data sources](#) — the pillar covering censuses, surveys and administrative data — against 50-69% on data use, data products and data infrastructure; it has [held no agricultural and no economic or business census in twenty years](#), and civil registration in the interior regions still runs on [handwritten paper registers](#). Its [Capacity of the Statistical System score rose 14.3 points over 2014-2023](#) and still reached only 35.4 out of 100 in 2023, 40th of 54 African states, and the Ibrahim Index [holds no data at all for 16 of its 96 indicators](#) for Djibouti, among them every public-perception measure.

A decree of 12 May 2026 created a statut particulier for INSTAD's cadres, a dedicated civil-service corps of statisticians, and the institute's [2026 forecast budget was approved at 485,686,344 Djiboutian francs](#). SNDS-3, the [third national statistics strategy for 2025-2029](#), financed by the World Bank, has been validated, and names [digitalising collection, database interoperability and disaggregated SDG statistics](#) as its challenges.

Labour-market statistics sit with a line ministry rather than the institute, in the [Observatoire de l'Emploi et des Qualifications inside the employment agency ANEFIP](#), whose founding decree requires an [employment and skills database built from administrative sources](#). INSTAD is [working with the World Bank-UNHCR Joint Data Center, IOM and UNHCR](#) to build a boosted displaced-population sample into the EDAM5 household survey.

The system rests on administrative-data streams held by line ministries as well as by the central institute: meteorology under a 2012 decree and employment under a 2015 decree both predate the 2025-2029 strategy by a decade.

Open data

Djibouti has [digitised and published online 126 years of the republic's legal record](#) as the Journal officiel, giving the state a complete official gazette in digital form (August 2026). The [e-JO platform is a searchable public legal-information service](#) drawing a few thousand consultations a month (March 2026), and President Guelleh presented it when Djibouti [hosted the African Forum of Official Journals, opening on 15 October 2025](#).

Little else is open. Across the categories the Open Data Inventory assessed in 2024, [no category reaches six out of ten](#): population and vital statistics score 5.5, and balance of payments, government finance, price statistics and gender statistics five. [Five categories score zero](#) — information and communications technology, agriculture, energy, pollution and poverty. On the Ibrahim Index, Djibouti scores [0.0 out of 100 on Disclosure of Public Records in 2023](#), last of 54 African states and down 12.5 points over the decade, and 8.7 on Accessibility of Public Records, 48th of 54; [Accountability and Transparency is its worst of the index's 16 sub-categories at 12.6 out of 100](#), 51st of 54, and its steepest ten-year decline.

Across the 23 categories the inventory records for Djibouti, mean openness comes to 3.1 out of ten (2024).

The rights exist on paper. [Title 2 of the Code du numérique](#) establishes a right of access to administrative documents and to the reuse of public data, and requires the government to publish an annual open-data catalogue; the [2018 land-property law](#) gives the public the right to consult the centralised electronic land register free of charge. Alongside them there is [no dedicated access-to-information statute](#) (April 2026). [Article 38 of the 2026 finance law](#) requires the budget-execution directorate to stand up a prices database and a data-exchange platform with every central-administration department. The central bank is one of the few publishers with a routine of its own, [issuing audited annual financial statements as downloadable documents](#).

Use of satellite data

The China Meteorological Administration [handed MAZU-Djibouti 2.0 to Djibouti on 17 July 2026](#) as a donation, an AI-driven monitoring and alerting system built on Chinese Fengyun satellite data that is generating port- and airport-facing weather alerts. The upgrade [sharpened forecast resolution from 9km to 3km, with three-day forecasts refreshed every six hours](#), and [added a terminal with integrated meteorological chips](#), completing a chain from space-based monitoring through modelling to one-click alerts. It builds on MAZU-Urban, [commissioned on 18 December 2025](#), which issues [port-safety, airport-weather and city-level heat and wind warnings up to 24 hours ahead](#) and implements a FOCAC commitment.

Djibouti's own programme is a different kind of asset. [HYDROSAT flies two 1U CubeSats](#) supervised by MENSUR through the Agence Spatiale Djiboutienne, and its [primary mission is store-and-forward data collection rather than imaging](#); the payload interrogates ground stations and relays up to 4.2MB per pass to the national research centre several times a day. The [secondary imaging payload resolves at 1km per pixel with files capped at 40KB](#), too coarse for crop-level or land-parcel observation. [DJIBOUTI-1A launched in November 2023](#) into a 525km sun-synchronous orbit giving two overflights a day and [DJIBOUTI-1B on 21 December 2024](#) into a 550km orbit giving roughly four; either can be [commanded from the agency's ground station or from Montpellier](#), and both carry a [two-year nominal mission life against a five-year orbital lifetime](#).

DJIBOUTI-1A passed that two-year mark around November 2025 and DJIBOUTI-1B reaches it in December 2026. The two postures point opposite ways on ownership: the sovereign asset is a coarse ground-station relay, while the operationally consequential capability — port and airport hazard alerting — runs on Chinese satellites, models and hardware, donated rather than procured.

Earth observation of the land itself is regional. IGAD, headquartered in Djibouti, [issued an expression of interest on 5 March 2026](#) for a consultant to build satellite-based crop-condition monitoring across the member states, [using vegetation, soil-moisture, land-surface-temperature and rainfall-anomaly indicators](#) to detect crop stress and feed ICPAC's regional early-warning dashboards. Domestically, a [JICA-supported project to modernise the management of geospatial information closed in December 2025](#), and the country's school estate has been [validated from satellite imagery on Giga Maps](#).

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

American engagement with Djibouti's digital layer runs through two firms rather than through Washington. Visa took the retail-payments side: a memorandum for a national Smart Wallet was [signed by Visa's regional head of Government Solutions for CEMEA opposite Djibouti's minister Mariam Hamadou Ali](#), during a three-day delegation to Djibouti led by senior executives of Visa and Tech5 (September 2025).

The infrastructure side is cable. Google announced in July 2021 that it was building the Raman submarine cable system with Sparkle and other partners, a 16-fibre-pair system landing in Djibouti alongside Jordan, Saudi Arabia, Oman and India. That system has since been claimed by others, presented by the European Commission in October 2025 as the physical layer of an EU-Africa-India Digital Corridor rather than as a bilateral American one.

China activities

China delivered a second artificial-intelligence weather-alerting terminal to Djibouti's national meteorological agency in July 2026, and neither that handover nor the first was announced with terms on cost, data ownership or exit. The first system was commissioned in December 2025 and generates port-safety, airport-weather and city-level alerts from Chinese Fengyun satellite data and AI forecasting, up to 24 hours ahead; a Shanghai delegation trained Djiboutian staff on site before handing it over, and the China Meteorological Administration presents the donation as implementing the consensus reached at the FOCAC Beijing summit of September 2025.

Djibouti has been courting Chinese capital for the compute layer on the same terms. Minister Dawaleh presented the country to China Exim Bank in Beijing in June 2026 as an emerging platform for artificial intelligence and digital innovation, within an industrial roadmap agreed with China. A month later a memorandum with Shanghai's LinkWise Group set out an AI compute centre, paired clean generation and a digital industrial park inside a dedicated special economic zone, presented by the signing minister as laying the foundations of national competitiveness for the next thirty years — a zone whose capital, chips, data corridor and operating company are all foreign, and whose stated success test is Djiboutian jurisdiction over data generated on Djiboutian territory. Minister Helem closed a Geneva mission in July 2026 seeking Chinese backing alongside ITU and Smart Africa support for the country's digital hub ambition.

The pattern predates the AI file. China's Ministry of Commerce financed the Urban Security Monitoring System, a video surveillance network for Djibouti City and the surrounding region, under an exchange of letters signed in 2017, with China Railway Construction Group taking the construction contract in April 2018 and China training Djiboutian public security agents that May.

EU activities

Italy has opened the most physical strand of European engagement. Fondazione Med-Or, working with Italy's foreign ministry under the Piano Mattei, is building Djiboutian capacity to inspect and protect the submarine cables at the landing station, under a memorandum with the Ministry of Economy and Finance covering critical infrastructure, digital connectivity and strategic dialogue; Italy's universities and research minister visited the station in August 2026 to open research and training cooperation.

The Union's own programme is modest beside the diplomacy around it. The EU has EUR 82 million in support for Djibouti over 2021-2027, financed mainly through NDICI-Global Europe and aligned with Global Gateway, delivered under a Team Europe arrangement that unites Germany and France alongside the European Investment Bank. Its named digital line items are MSME digital capacity, women's economic leadership in digital trade and the promotion of digital skills, with the governance strand extending to digitalisation of public services, including an e-cabinet and an e-permit system.

Skills is where the money has actually landed: an EU-funded E-SKILLS programme implemented by Expertise France with the digital ministry launched on 24 November 2025, targeting young people and women through Campus 42 Djibouti and regional Maisons du Numerique, and Djibouti has launched a tuition-free École 42 coding school with the European Union, Expertise France and Association 42 (April 2026).

On connectivity the framing runs ahead of the finance. Team Europe presented the Blue Raman cable as a concrete Global Gateway delivery at the Global Gateway Forum in Brussels on 10 October 2025, naming Djibouti a landing country, where the European Investment Bank and the cable's promoter Sparkle also formalised their collaboration. Djibouti sits on one of the eleven strategic corridors announced at the February 2022 EU-African Union summit, running Dar es Salaam-Nairobi-Addis Ababa-Berbera-Djibouti; the Commission's Joint Research Centre, assessing all eleven, found digitalisation the most challenging objective of the set and attached no funding decision to the exercise, which exists to help the EU Delegation, the EIB and member states decide where to invest next.

Gulf/UAE activities

Gulf engagement with Djibouti's digital economy shows up so far as a labour-market question rather than an investment one: Gulf Cooperation Council placements for graduates of Djibouti's SKILLS Project were still under discussion in April 2026, by which point sixteen of the programme's candidates had been placed in employment in Canada.

India activities

Djibouti has begun courting Indian industry directly for its AI ambitions. Working through India's ESC export-promotion council, the government invited Indian AI companies to its National Forum on Artificial Intelligence of 2-3 September 2026, offering visa-support letters and presenting the Forum's official launch of the national AI strategy as a platform for business partnerships, technology collaboration and investment (July 2026), placing India alongside China as a courted partner on artificial intelligence.

India's other route in is the cable. The European Commission presented the EU-Africa-India Digital Corridor, centred on the 11,700 km Blue Raman system landing in Djibouti, India and Oman, as a concrete deliverable under the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor announced at the September 2023 G20 summit in New Delhi, with an accompanying memorandum pairing Europe's GEANT research network with India's National Knowledge Network and Africa's UbuntuNet Alliance for research and education connectivity (October 2025).

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